

Personal Homepage Design Document

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1. Project Description

A personal homepage built with vanilla HTML5, CSS3, and ES6+ JavaScript | no frameworks, no libraries.

The site is part portfolio, part personality. The design uses an editorial magazine structure: ruled lines, condensed type labels, and newspaper-column layouts instead of the standard centered card grid.

Goals

- Present work and experience in a way that reflects who I am, not just a list of credentials.
- Demonstrate front-end fundamentals: semantic HTML, organized CSS with a design token system, modular ES6 JavaScript.
- Include one original, non-trivial JS feature | an interactive terminal where visitors type commands to learn about me.
- Be accessible, W3C compliant, and deployable with no external runtime dependencies.

Scope

Two hand-coded pages (homepage and projects) plus a third AI-generated page. The homepage has a masthead, scrolling tech ticker, about section, experience table, featured projects, and the terminal. The projects page adds live tag filtering.

2. User Personas

Persona 1 | Maya, 34, Engineering Manager

Maya is reviewing candidates for a new grad software engineering role. She has a stack of portfolios to get through and about 90 seconds per site before deciding whether to keep reading. She wants to confirm relevant experience, find a GitHub link, and get a read on whether someone would fit her team.

Goals:

- Confirm relevant experience and tech stack without hunting.
- Find contact info or a GitHub link immediately.
- Get a sense of personality from the writing.

Frustrations:

- Sites that bury contact info or make you click three times to find GitHub.
- No visual hierarchy | everything the same size and weight.

Persona 2 | Jordan, 21, CS Junior

Jordan heard about a Go and Supabase project and wants to see what it looks like. He's on a laptop between classes, casually curious, and will click a GitHub link if he finds one. He doesn't need anything explained to him.

Goals:

- Find specific projects and understand what they actually do.
- See the tech stack. Maybe borrow some ideas.

Frustrations:

- Project pages that are just a link dump with no context.
- Sites that feel like a resume printed to HTML.

Persona 3 | Dave, 52, Family Friend

Dave got the link forwarded by Ally's parents. He has no technical background and is probably on his phone on a weekend morning. He wants to come away feeling like he understands what Ally does and that it's impressive.

Goals:

- Understand what Ally does well enough to explain it to someone else.
- Have the site look professional and work on his phone.

Frustrations:

- Acronym soup with no plain-language explanation.
- Layouts that break on mobile.

3. User Stories

Story 1 | The 90-Second Screen (Maya)

Maya gets Ally's site link from a recruiter email on a Tuesday afternoon, right between two back-to-back interviews. The page loads immediately | no spinner. She sees the name, role, and university in the header. The hero sidebar says 'Open to new grad roles' and lists a Datadog internship. She scrolls to the experience table, sees Verisk and TJX, and clicks GitHub in the nav. Active repos, readable commit history. She flags Ally for a callback. Total time: under two minutes.

Acceptance criteria:

- Name, role, and status are visible in the hero without scrolling.
- GitHub and LinkedIn links are in the nav on every page.
- Experience section shows company names and dates clearly.
- Page loads without a spinner or splash screen.

Story 2 | The Project Deep Dive (Jordan)

Jordan pulls up the site while waiting for office hours. He clicks Projects, hits the Go filter, and the list narrows instantly | no reload. He reads the Arenius description, clicks GitHub, and ends up in the backend routes. On the way back he notices the terminal, types 'skills', and gets a clean list. He types 'hire' as a joke, gets an easter egg, and stays on the site longer than he planned.

Acceptance criteria:

- Tag filter updates the project list without a page reload.
- Each project has a working GitHub link that opens in a new tab.
- Terminal responds to 'skills', 'help', and unknown commands without breaking.
- Arrow keys navigate command history in the terminal.

Story 3 | The Proud Parent Forward (Dave)

Ally's mom texts Dave the link on a Saturday morning. He opens it on his iPhone. The header is readable. He sees 'Software Engineer' and 'Northeastern University.' He scrolls through the about section and reads about the co-ops. He doesn't know what a carbon accounting platform is, but 'helps small businesses track their environmental impact' makes sense. He shows his wife.

Acceptance criteria:

- Site is usable on mobile without horizontal scrolling or broken layouts.
- Project descriptions include plain-language context alongside the tech stack.
- About section reads naturally, not like a resume bullet list.

4. Technical Design Notes

- **Colors:** Warm paper background (#f5f0e8), ink black (#1a1713), terracotta red accent (#c0392b), light rule color (#c8bfad) for dividers and muted labels.
- **Typography:** Playfair Display for headlines, Barlow + Barlow Condensed for body and labels, IBM Plex Mono for code and metadata.
- **Layout:** CSS Grid for the main content areas, Flexbox for the nav and filter bar. Two-column hero, three-column projects grid, single-column table for experience.

- **Interactions:** Scroll-triggered counter animation, staggered experience row reveal, tag filter without page reload, infinite ticker, command-line terminal with history navigation.

5. Layout Wireframe Diagrams

Figure 4.1: Homepage Layout (index.html)

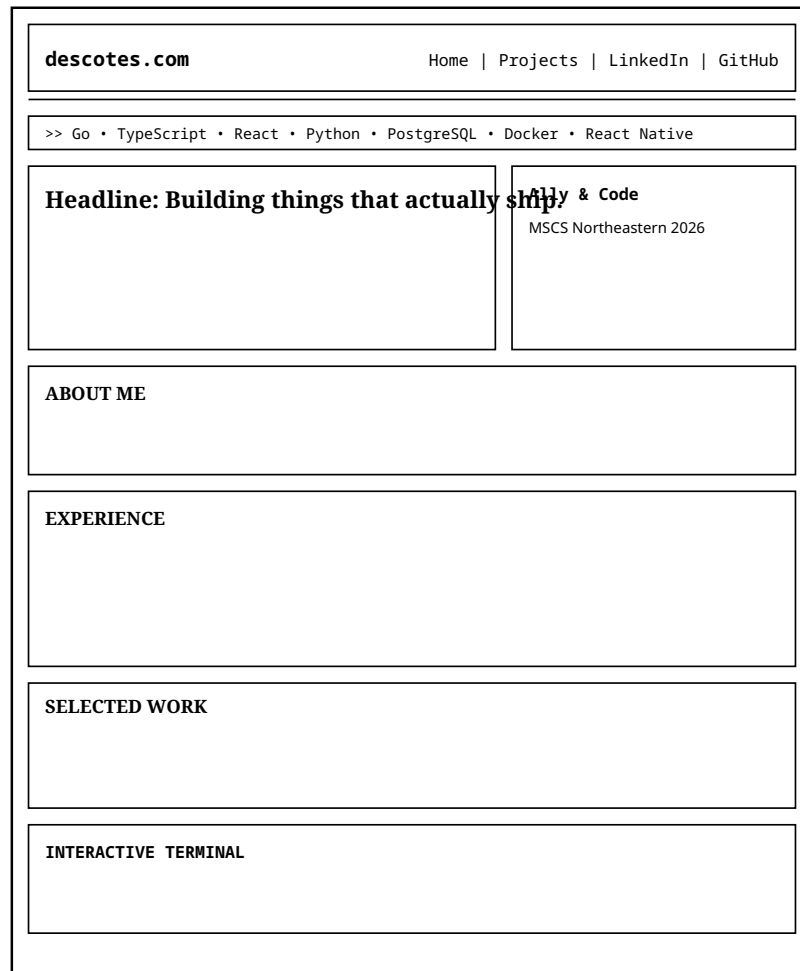


Figure 4.2: Projects Page Layout (pages/projects.html)

descotes.com
Selected Work Architecture
Filter: [All] [Go] [React] [TypeScript]
01. Castaway
02. Arenius